

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Corporate Strategy English

Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

03 Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

08 Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Diagnosis - Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now.

Ambition - High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve.

Strategic thesis - Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value.

Issue tree - Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Strategic choice - Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

Tradeoff - A deliberate decision to deprioritize one attractive option to make another choice coherent.

Activity system - Reinforcing set of activities that makes a strategy harder to copy.

Opportunity cost - Value sacrificed by keeping scarce resources in a lower-priority use.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - B. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - C. An increase of one percentage point.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

TAM - Total addressable market; full demand opportunity if all relevant customers were served.

SAM - Serviceable available market; portion the company can realistically reach with its offer and model.

SOM - Serviceable obtainable market; share the company can reasonably capture.

Profit pool - Where profit accumulates across segments, value chain positions, or business models.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Without any uncertainty, the result is ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In every location, the result will be ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Value driver - Factor that materially affects enterprise value, such as growth, margin, capital intensity, or risk.

ROIC - Return on invested capital; profit relative to capital invested in the business.

Margin expansion - Improvement in profitability as a share of revenue.

Right to win - Credible basis for outperforming alternatives in that market.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog must be reviewed at the backlog meeting.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is an important operational backlog.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. I have explained the next step, so shall we finish?
 - C. You understand everything now, don't you?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Capital allocation - Decision process for assigning capital to businesses, initiatives, acquisitions, or returns.

Core business - Current business central to revenue, profit, capabilities, or strategic identity.

Divestiture - Sale, exit, or separation of a business, asset, or product line.

Adjacency - Growth area near the core by customer, channel, capability, geography, or value chain.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Improve this sentence: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we review yesterday's schedule.
 - C. If the scope changed tomorrow, we reviewed the schedule yesterday.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Market entry - Plan to enter a new geography, segment, category, or value-chain position.

Build-buy-partner - Comparison of internal development, acquisition, and partnership routes.

Synergy - Incremental value from combining businesses, assets, capabilities, customers, or costs.

PMI - Post-merger integration; work required to combine and realize value after a deal.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Without any uncertainty, the result is ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In every location, the result will be ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Scenario planning - Structured analysis of plausible futures and their implications for decisions.

Residual uncertainty - Uncertainty remaining after strong analysis has been completed.

Trigger indicator - Signal that shows which scenario may be unfolding and when to revisit a decision.

Strategic option - Limited investment that preserves future ability to scale, pivot, or exit.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Operating model - How structure, roles, processes, governance, incentives, and capabilities support strategy.

Decision rights - Clarity on who recommends, decides, executes, and escalates.

KPI - Key performance indicator tied to a strategic objective or decision.

Board narrative - Concise strategy story for oversight, alignment, and decision-making.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Improve this sentence: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
 - B. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - C. We can record their agreement without asking them.
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.
 - B. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - C. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After checking the answer section, revise one sentence and try the spoken response again.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response, not a script to memorize. Your written version needs a subject line, an opening, and appropriate context. Assess it using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

B: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

C: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

Check 2: C - An increase of one percentage point.

A: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

B: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

C: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

Model response: The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This removes uncertainty rather than explaining its limits.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: The pilot does not establish future results everywhere.

Model response: Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes a meeting but leaves the term unexplained.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Repeating the same term does not define it.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Finishing the conversation gives no evidence of understanding.

C: This leading question makes it easy to agree without showing understanding.

Model response: Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the if-clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The if-clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: The tense pattern and time reference do not express the intended future condition.

C: The conflicting time references make the condition unclear.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This removes uncertainty rather than explaining its limits.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: The pilot does not establish future results everywhere.

Model response: These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

B: Silence does not establish agreement.

C: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

Check 2: C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

B: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

C: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

Model response: The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.